

Word family: **speak / speaks / spoke / spoken / speaking / speaker / speech / spoken**

Base word: speak

Third-person singular: speaks

Past tense: spoke

Past participle: spoken

** -ing form:** speaking

Related forms: speaker, speech, spoken

Useful constructions/extensions: speak to/with someone, speak about/on something, speak in front of an audience, speak a language, speak for someone, speak for itself, speak your mind, generally/strictly speaking, speaking of, on speaking terms, public speaking, speaker, spoken English

Part of speech: mainly verb (動詞) / related noun and adjective forms (相關名詞及形容詞)

Your passage contains several forms:

> “I had never **spoken** to such a large audience in English before.”

> “While I was **speaking**, I focused on a few friendly faces in the audience...”

and later:

> “Even a short pause felt huge.”

The target meaning is therefore closely connected with **public speaking** and **speaking English before an audience**.

Meaning in this passage

In:

> “I had never **spoken to such a large audience in English** before.”

speak means:

to address a group of people orally, using English as the language of communication.

It is not merely casual conversation with one person.

You were:

* standing in front of a large audience;

* formally presenting a work project;

* using English;

* speaking continuously for an organized presentation.

****Meaning:**** To communicate orally to an audience, especially in a prepared or formal setting.

****繁體中文:**** ****** 在一群聽眾面前以口語正式表達、講解或發言******

****中文翻譯:****

> “I had never spoken to such a large audience in English before.”

「我以前從來沒有試過******用英文向這麼多觀眾發言／演講******。」

And:

> “While I was speaking, I focused on a few friendly faces in the audience...”

「當我******正在台上發言／說話******時，我把注意力放在幾張比較友善的面孔上.....」

So:

****speak to an audience = 向一群聽眾發言／演講********

****speak in English = 用英語口頭表達********

1. ****speak = talk / say words aloud (說話) — 說話; 開口********

This is the broad basic meaning.

****Meaning:**** To use your voice to say words.

Practice 1

> “She was too nervous to ****speak****.”

「她太緊張，幾乎******說不出話來******。」

Practice 2

> “Please ****speak**** clearly.”

「請******說清楚一點******。」

****speak = 用聲音說出語言內容****

This is the broad core from which many other uses develop.

2. ****speak to/with + person (與某人說話) — 跟……說話; 交談****

Practice 3

> “Can I ****speak to**** your manager?”

「我可以****跟你們的經理談一下****嗎？」

Practice 4

> “I ****spoke with**** my supervisor before the event.”

「活動前我****跟上司談過****。」

****speak to/with someone = 與某人進行口頭交流****

Both ****speak to**** and ****speak with**** are common.

****Speak with**** can sometimes sound slightly more mutual/conversational.

3. ****speak to an audience (向觀眾發言) — 對觀眾演講; 發言****

This is the exact contextual sense in your passage.

Practice 5 — Original

> “I had never ****spoken to such a large audience**** in English before.”

「我以前從來沒有試過****用英文向這麼多觀眾發言****。」

Practice 6

> “She was invited to ****speak to**** more than five hundred employees.”

「她獲邀****向五百多名員工發言****。」

Practice 7

> “He regularly ****speaks to large audiences**** at conferences.”

「他經常在會議上****向大批觀眾演講****。」

****speak to an audience = 以講者身份向一群聽眾正式或半正式地發言****

4. ****speak in public / public speaking (公開演講) — 公開發言 ; 公開演講****

A highly relevant extension for your passage.

Practice 8

> “I used to be afraid of ****speaking in public****.”

「我以前很害怕****公開演講／在人前發言****。」

Practice 9

> “****Public speaking**** becomes easier with practice.”

「****公開演講****會隨著練習變得容易一些。」

****speak in public = 在一群人面前公開發言****

****public speaking = 公開演講這項活動／能力****

This is central to your passage.

5. ****speak + language (語言能力) — 說 ; 會說某種語言****

A major separate grammatical pattern.

Practice 10

> “She ****speaks English**** fluently.”

「她****英語說得很流利****。」

Practice 11

> “Do you ****speak Cantonese****?”

「你**會說廣東話**嗎？」

****speak + language = 能夠使用某種語言進行口頭交流****

Common:

* speak English

* speak French

* speak Cantonese

* speak several languages

6. ****speak in + language (用某種語言說話) — 用.....說****

This differs slightly from general language ability.

Practice 12

> “I had to ****speak in English**** during the presentation.”

「我做簡報時必須**用英文發言**。」

Practice 13

> “Please ****speak in English**** during the exercise.”

「練習期間請**使用英語說話**。」

****speak in + language = 在某個具體場合使用該語言進行口頭表達****

Compare:

> ****I speak English.****

= 我會說英語。

> ****I spoke in English at the meeting.****

= 我在會議上用英語發言。

7. **speak about/on + topic (談論主題) — 談; 發表關於.....的內容**

Practice 14

> “She **spoke about** the challenges of leading a team.”

「她**談到**帶領團隊的挑戰。」

Practice 15

> “The professor will **speak on** climate policy.”

「教授會就氣候政策**發表演講**。」

speak about/on something = 以口頭方式討論、講解或發表某個主題

Speak on often sounds more formal and is common for talks/lectures.

8. **speak at + event/conference (在活動上發言) — 在.....演講**

Practice 16

> “She **spoke at** the annual conference.”

「她在年度會議上**發表演講**。」

Practice 17

> “He has been invited to **speak at** the company event.”

「他獲邀在公司活動上**發言**。」

speak at + event = 在某個活動、會議或場合中以講者身份發言

This is especially relevant to professional English.

9. **speak for + person/group (代表某人／團體發言) — 代表.....說話**

A genuinely different sense.

Practice 18

> “I cannot **speak for** the whole team.”

「我不能**代表整個團隊發言**。」

Practice 19

> “She was authorized to **speak for** the organization.”

「她獲授權**代表該機構發言**。」

speak for someone/group = 代表某人或某團體表達立場、意見或決定

This is different from merely talking **to** them.

10. **speak for yourself**(只代表你自己) — 只代表你自己的意見

A very common fixed expression.

Practice 20

> “Everyone hates presentations.”

> “**Speak for yourself.**”

「每個人都討厭做簡報。」

「**那只是你的看法，別代表其他人。**」

Practice 21

> “We all think the plan is boring.”

> “**Speak for yourself.** I like it.”

「我們都覺得這個計劃很悶。」

「**你只代表自己吧。我覺得不錯。**」

****speak for yourself = 不要把自己的意見當成所有人的意見****

Often mildly challenging or humorous.

11. ****something speaks for itself(不言自明) — 事實本身已說明一切****

A strong figurative meaning.

Practice 22

> “The improvement in sales ****speaks for itself****.”

「銷售表現的改善****本身已說明一切／不言自明****。」

Practice 23

> “Her results ****speak for themselves****.”

「她的成績****本身就是最好的證明****。」

****something speaks for itself = 某件事的證據或結果已經非常清楚, 不需要再額外解釋****

No literal speaking occurs.

12. ****speak well/highly of someone(給予正面評價) — 對.....評價很好****

Practice 24

> “Her colleagues ****spoke highly of**** her work.”

「她的同事都****高度評價她的工作****。」

Practice 25

> “The manager ****spoke well of**** your presentation.”

「經理對你的簡報****評價很好****。」

****speak highly/well of someone/something = 以正面、讚賞的方式談論某人／某事****

13. **speak badly/poorly of someone (負面評論) — 說.....壞話; 負面評價**

Practice 26

> “He never **speaks badly of** former colleagues.”

「他從不**說前同事壞話**。」

Practice 27

> “It is unprofessional to **speak poorly of** clients.”

「對客戶作出**負面評論**是不專業的。」

speak badly/poorly of = 對某人／某事作負面評價

14. **speak your mind (坦率說出想法) — 直言; 說出真實想法**

A very useful idiom.

Practice 28

> “She is not afraid to **speak her mind**.”

「她不怕**坦率說出自己的想法**。」

Practice 29

> “I decided to **speak my mind** during the meeting.”

「我決定在會議上**坦白說出自己的意見**。」

speak your mind = 坦率直接地說出自己真正的想法或感受

15. **speak out (公開表態) — 公開說出意見**

This is a phrasal verb, so under the default rule it would normally be handled separately.

Still, it is worth flagging as a family extension because it is common.

Practice 30

> “Several employees ****spoke out**** about the problem.”

「幾名員工****公開就問題發表意見****。」

Practice 31

> “She decided to ****speak out**** against unfair treatment.”

「她決定****公開反對不公平待遇****。」

****speak out** = 公開而明確地表達意見, 尤其針對問題或不公******

16. ****speak up** (提高聲量／勇敢發言) — 大聲一點; 挺身發言******

Another important phrasal extension.

A. Louder

> “Could you ****speak up****?”

「你可以****說大聲一點****嗎？」

B. Express an opinion

> “Employees should ****speak up**** when they see a problem.”

「員工看到問題時應該****勇於發言／提出意見****。」

****speak up** = 提高說話聲量, 或勇敢地表達意見******

Because this is a phrasal verb, it is not a core bare-****speak**** sense.

17. ****not speak to someone** (不理某人／不跟某人說話) — 不跟……說話******

A common interpersonal use.

Practice 32

> “They argued and didn’t ****speak to each other**** for a week.”

「他們吵架後整整一星期都****沒有跟對方說話****。」

Practice 33

> “She was so angry that she refused to ****speak to him****.”

「她氣得拒絕****跟他說話****。」

****not speak to someone** = 因生氣、衝突等而不願跟某人交談******

Context can make this stronger than simply “not happen to talk.”

18. ****be on speaking terms** (仍有基本交談關係) — 尚有來往; 仍會說話******

A useful fixed expression.

Practice 34

> “They disagree often, but they are still ****on speaking terms****.”

「他們雖然經常意見不合, 但仍然****保持基本來往、仍會交談****。」

Practice 35

> “After the argument, they were no longer ****on speaking terms****.”

「爭吵後, 他們已經****互不理睬／不再交談****。」

****be on speaking terms** = 雙方關係至少好到仍願意互相說話******

19. ****speaking voice** (說話聲線) — 說話時的聲音******

Practice 36

> “She has a calm ****speaking voice****.”

「她的**說話聲線**很平靜。」

Practice 37

> “Use your normal **speaking voice**.”

「請使用你平常的**說話聲量／聲線**。」

speaking voice = 一個人在正常說話時所使用的聲音

Contrast:

> singing voice

= 歌唱聲線

20. **spoken language / spoken English (口語) — 口語的; 口頭使用的**

Spoken functions as an adjective here.

Practice 38

> “His **spoken English** has improved a lot.”

「他的**英語口語能力**進步了很多。」

Practice 39

> “There is often a difference between written and **spoken language**.”

「書面語和**口語**之間經常有差異。」

spoken = 以口頭形式說出／使用的, 而不是書寫的

Common:

* spoken English

* spoken language

* spoken communication

* spoken word

21. ****spoken word**(口頭語言／朗誦表演) — 口頭表達; 口語藝術******

This expression has two common uses.

A. Speech rather than writing

> “The message was delivered by the ****spoken word****.”

「訊息是透過****口頭語言****傳達的。」

B. Performance art

> “She performs ****spoken-word poetry****.”

「她表演****口語詩／朗誦詩****。」

****spoken word** = 口頭表達的語言; 亦可指以口語朗誦為核心的表演形式******

22. ****speaker** = person who is speaking(講者) — 講者; 發言者******

A highly relevant related noun.

Practice 40

> “The ****speaker**** answered questions after the presentation.”

「****講者****在簡報後回答問題。」

Practice 41

> “Each ****speaker**** has ten minutes.”

「每位****發言者****有十分鐘。」

****speaker** = 正在發言、演講或向觀眾說話的人******

23. ****speaker** = loudspeaker/device(揚聲器) — 喇叭; 揚聲器******

A completely different noun meaning.

Practice 42

> “The music was coming from a small **speaker**.”

「音樂是從一個小型**揚聲器**傳出來的。」

Practice 43

> “The room has built-in **speakers**.”

「房間設有內置**喇叭／揚聲器**。」

speaker = 把電子音訊轉換成可聽聲音的裝置

This is a major polysemy point within the family.

24. **Speaker** = presiding officer (議長／主持議會者) — 議長

Capitalized in official titles.

Practice 44

> “The **Speaker** called the meeting to order.”

「**議長**宣布會議開始。」

Practice 45

> “Members addressed their comments to the **Speaker**.”

「議員把發言對象指向**議長**。」

Speaker = 負責主持議會、議院或正式立法會議的人

This is an institutional title and should be distinguished from ordinary **speaker**.

25. **speech** = act/content of formal speaking (演講) — 演講; 講話

A major related noun.

Practice 46

> “She gave a short **speech** at the event.”

「她在活動上作了一次簡短**演講**。」

Practice 47

> “His **speech** focused on teamwork.”

「他的**演講**主要談團隊合作。」

speech = 在觀眾面前正式發表的一段口頭內容／演講活動

26. **speech** = ability to speak (說話能力) — 言語能力; 說話

A different noun sense.

Practice 48

> “The injury temporarily affected his **speech**.”

「受傷暫時影響了他的**說話能力**。」

Practice 49

> “The child’s **speech** developed normally.”

「這名兒童的**語言／說話能力**正常發展。」

speech = 人類產生口語、說話和發音的能力

Common in medical and developmental contexts.

27. **speech** = way of speaking (說話方式) — 語音; 說話模式

Practice 50

> “His **speech** became faster when he was nervous.”

「他緊張時**說話速度**會加快。」

Practice 51

> “The software analyzes patterns in human **speech**.”

「該軟件分析人類**語音／說話模式**。」

speech = 人實際說話時的聲音、速度、節奏、發音等整體表現

28. **speech = language contrasted with writing (口語) — 口語; 言語**

Practice 52

> “The expression is common in everyday **speech**.”

「這個表達在日常**口語**中很常見。」

Practice 53

> “Written English is often more formal than everyday **speech**.”

「書面英語通常比日常**口語**更正式。」

speech = 實際口頭語言的使用, 而不是書面文字

29. **freedom of speech (言論自由) — 言論自由**

A highly important fixed expression.

Practice 54

> “The law protects **freedom of speech**.”

「法律保障**言論自由**。」

Practice 55

> “The debate raised questions about **free speech**.”

「這場辯論引發了有關**言論自由**的問題。」

freedom of speech = 公開表達意見、思想和觀點的權利

30. **figure of speech** (修辭) — 修辭手法; 比喻性說法

A useful language-learning compound.

Practice 56

> “That expression is a **figure of speech**.”

「那個表達是一種**修辭說法**。」

Practice 57

> “The phrase should not be understood literally; it is a **figure of speech**.”

「這句話不應按字面理解; 它是一種**修辭手法**。」

figure of speech = 不完全按字面意思使用語言的修辭表達方式

31. **generally speaking** (一般而言) — 一般來說

A very common discourse expression.

Practice 58

> “**Generally speaking**, preparation reduces nervousness.”

「**一般來說**, 充分準備可以減少緊張。」

Practice 59

> “**Generally speaking**, larger audiences require more preparation.”

「**一般而言**, 面對較多觀眾需要更多準備。」

****generally speaking = 從整體／一般情況來看****

This does not refer to literal speaking.

32. ****strictly speaking (嚴格來說) — 嚴格而言****

Practice 60

> **“**Strictly speaking** , this is not a formal requirement.”**

「****嚴格來說****, 這不是正式要求。」

Practice 61

> **“**Strictly speaking** , the two words are not exact synonyms.”**

「****嚴格而言****, 這兩個詞並不是完全同義。」

****strictly speaking = 如果按照最準確、最嚴格的定義來說****

33. ****technically speaking (從技術上來說) — 從嚴格／技術定義來說****

Practice 62

> **“**Technically speaking** , the project was already complete.”**

「****從技術定義來說****, 項目其實已經完成。」

Practice 63

> **“**Technically speaking** , the device is a computer.”**

「****嚴格從技術分類來說****, 這個裝置屬於電腦。」

****technically speaking = 從專業、技術或嚴格定義的角度而言****

34. ****speaking of + topic (說到……) — 說到; 提起****

A very common conversational expression.

Practice 64

> “**Speaking of presentations**, how did yours go?”

「**說到簡報**，你的那次怎樣？」

Practice 65

> “**Speaking of work**, have you finished the report?”

「**說到工作**，你完成報告了嗎？」

speaking of + noun = 因為剛才的話題令人聯想到另一件相關事情，而把話題轉過去

Very common in conversation.

35. **so to speak (可以這樣說; 打個比方) — 可以這樣說; 某程度上說**

A useful idiom.

Practice 66

> “The presentation was my first real test, **so to speak**.”

「那次簡報**可以說是我第一次真正的考驗。」

Practice 67

> “He became the face of the team, **so to speak**.”

「他**某程度上可以說是團隊的代表人物。」

so to speak = 表示說法帶比喻、近似或不完全按字面理解; 可以這樣說

36. **speak volumes (很能說明問題) — 充分說明; 很有代表性**

An important figurative idiom.

Practice 68

> “Her calm response ****spoke volumes**** about her confidence.”

「她冷靜的反應****充分顯示了她的自信****。」

Practice 69

> “The audience’s silence ****spoke volumes****.”

「觀眾的沉默****已經充分說明了情況****。」

****speak volumes = 雖然沒有直接說出，但某種行為、反應或證據已經傳達大量信息****

37. ****actions/results speak louder than words** (行動比言語更有說服力) — 行動勝於空談******

A very common expression.

Practice 70

> “Her results ****speak louder than words****.”

「她的成果****比口頭說法更有說服力****。」

Practice 71

> “In leadership, actions often ****speak louder than words****.”

「在領導工作中，****行動往往比說話更有說服力****。」

****actions speak louder than words = 實際行動比口頭承諾更能證明一個人的真正態度或能力****

38. ****speaking terms** (交談關係) — 尚會互相交談的關係******

Practice 72

> “They are no longer on ****speaking terms****.”

「他們已經****互不理睬／不再說話****。」

Practice 73

> “At least they are still on **speaking terms**.”

「至少他們現在仍然**願意互相說話**。」

on speaking terms = 關係至少維持到仍願意彼此交談

39. **speaking part/role** (有台詞的角色) — 有對白的角色

A useful theatre/media meaning.

Practice 74

> “She got a small **speaking role** in the film.”

「她在電影中得到一個小型**有對白角色**。」

Practice 75

> “Several extras were upgraded to **speaking parts**.”

「幾位臨時演員被提升為**有台詞的角色**。」

speaking role/part = 在電影、戲劇等作品中有需要說台詞的角色

40. **speaker** = native/non-native speaker (某語言使用者) — 某語言說者

Practice 76

> “She is a native English **speaker**.”

「她是英語**母語使用者**。」

Practice 77

> “The course is designed for non-native **speakers**.”

「這個課程是為**非母語使用者**而設。」

****speaker of a language = 能使用某種語言說話的人****

Common:

- * native speaker
- * non-native speaker
- * Cantonese speaker
- * English speaker

Important distinction: **speak vs talk**

These overlap strongly, but the patterns differ.

**speak**

often sounds:

- * more formal;
- * more focused on one person addressing others;
- * especially natural for language ability.

> “She ****spoke**** at the conference.”

> “He ****speaks**** English.”

**talk**

often emphasizes:

- * conversation;
- * informal exchange;
- * discussion.

> “We ****talked**** for an hour.”

> “Can we ****talk****?”

Both can occur in many contexts.

Compare:

> ****speak to an audience****

very natural for a presentation

> **talk to an audience**

also possible, often slightly less formal.

For your passage, **speak** fits naturally because the setting is formal public communication.

Important distinction: speak vs say

This is crucial.

speak

focuses on the act/ability of oral communication:

> “She **speaks** clearly.”

say

focuses on the words/content communicated:

> “She **said** that she was nervous.”

Normally:

>  speak to someone

but:

>  say something to someone

Not:

>  say someone

So:

speak = 進行說話／口頭交流

say = 說出某段內容

Important distinction: ****speak vs tell****

****speak****

> speak to/with someone

****tell****

usually needs a person/object:

> tell someone something

> “She ****told me**** the truth.”

Compare:

> “I ****spoke to my supervisor****.”

= 我跟上司談過。

> “I ****told my supervisor the problem****.”

= 我把問題告訴了上司。

So:

****speak = 交談／發言本身****

****tell = 把某個具體內容告訴某人****

Important distinction: ****speak a language vs talk a language****

For language ability:

>  ****speak English****

is standard.

>  ****talk English****

is generally not the normal expression for language ability.

You can say:

> “We talked in English.”

= 我們用英語交談。

So:

****speak + language****

but:

****talk in + language****

for a particular conversation.

Important distinction: **speak English vs speak in English**

**speak English**

= have the ability to use English orally

> “I speak English.”

「我會說英語。」

**speak in English**

= use English in a particular situation

> “I spoke in English during the presentation.”

「我在簡報中用英語發言。」

Your passage contains the second contextual idea.

Important distinction: **speak to vs speak with**

Both are correct.

speak to

can be:

- * neutral;
- * one-directional;
- * slightly more formal.

speak with

often emphasizes mutual conversation.

Compare:

> “The manager will **speak to** the staff.”

could mean address them.

> “I **spoke with** the manager about the problem.”

strongly suggests discussion.

The distinction is not absolute.

Important distinction: **speak for vs speak to**

speak to someone

= talk/address them

speak for someone

= represent them or express their view

> “I spoke **to** the team.”

= 我向團隊說話。

> “I spoke **for** the team.”

= 我代表團隊發言。

Very different meanings.

Important distinction: ****speak for someone vs represent someone****

These overlap in some contexts.

****speak for someone****

focuses specifically on:

> expressing their views or position orally/in communication.

****represent someone****

is broader:

> act on their behalf in meetings, negotiations, legal matters, events, etc.

In your passage:

> “represent the team”

is broader than merely:

> “speak for the team.”

Important distinction: ****speech vs presentation****

****speech****

often means a prepared spoken address, usually with less emphasis on slides/data structure.

****presentation****

often includes:

* visuals;

- * slides;
- * structured information;
- * explanation of a topic/project.

Your workplace example is naturally:

> **a presentation**

rather than necessarily:

> a speech.

But both involve **speaking to an audience**.

Important distinction: **speech vs speaking**

**speech**

can mean:

- * a formal talk;
- * speaking ability;
- * spoken language.

**speaking**

often means:

- * the activity/skill of speaking.

Compare:

> **public speaking**

= 公開演講這項技能／活動

> **a public speech**

= 一場公開演講

So:

****speaking = 活動／能力****

****speech = 一次演講或言語本身****

Important distinction: **speaker = person vs speaker = device**

A major family contrast.

Person:

> “The ****speaker**** answered questions.”

= 講者回答問題。

Device:

> “The sound came from the ****speaker****.”

= 聲音從揚聲器傳出。

Same spelling, completely different lexical concept.

Important distinction: **spoken vs written**

**spoken English**

= English as actually used orally

**written English**

= English as used in writing

Spoken English often contains:

- * contractions;
- * shorter structures;
- * discourse markers;
- * hesitation;
- * more conversational expressions.

Your task involved ****spoken English****, because you were delivering the presentation orally.

Important distinction: **spoken vs speaking**

**spoken**

often describes something that is expressed orally:

> spoken English

> spoken instructions

**speaking**

often describes:

* the activity;

* a role involving speech.

> speaking practice

> speaking role

> public speaking

So:

****spoken = 已用口頭形式表達的／口語的****

****speaking = 與說話活動有關的****

Important distinction: **generally speaking vs speaking generally**

Both are possible, but:

> ****generally speaking****

is the standard fixed expression meaning:

****一般來說****

It should be learned as a chunk.

Family-extension sweep

The practical **“speak”** family is rich in both lexical meanings and grammatical/fixed constructions:

- * **“speak = say words aloud”** = 說話
- * **“speak to/with someone”** = 跟某人交談
- * **“speak to an audience”** = 向觀眾發言
- * **“speak in public”** = 公開演講
- * **“public speaking”** = 公開演講這項能力／活動
- * **“speak + language”** = 會說某種語言
- * **“speak in + language”** = 在某場合用某種語言說話
- * **“speak about/on”** = 談論／發表某主題
- * **“speak at an event”** = 在活動上演講
- * **“speak for someone”** = 代表某人／團體發言
- * **“speak for yourself”** = 只代表自己的意見
- * **“speak for itself”** = 不言自明／本身已是證明
- * **“speak highly/well of”** = 給予正面評價
- * **“speak badly/poorly of”** = 負面評價
- * **“speak your mind”** = 坦率說出想法
- * **“speak out”** = 公開表態
- * **“speak up”** = 說大聲一點／勇於發言
- * **“on speaking terms”** = 仍有交談關係
- * **“speaking voice”** = 說話聲線
- * **“spoken English/language”** = 口語英語／口語
- * **“spoken word”** = 口頭語言／朗誦表演
- * **“speaker — person”** = 講者
- * **“speaker — device”** = 揚聲器
- * **“Speaker — institutional title”** = 議長
- * **“speaker of a language”** = 某語言使用者
- * **“speech — formal talk”** = 演講
- * **“speech — ability”** = 說話能力
- * **“speech — way of speaking”** = 語音／說話模式
- * **“speech — spoken language”** = 口語
- * **“freedom of speech”** = 言論自由
- * **“figure of speech”** = 修辭
- * **“generally speaking”** = 一般而言
- * **“strictly speaking”** = 嚴格來說
- * **“technically speaking”** = 從技術／嚴格定義來說
- * **“speaking of”** = 說到／提起

- * **so to speak** = 可以這樣說／某程度上說
- * **speak volumes** = 充分說明很多事情
- * **actions speak louder than words** = 行動勝於空談
- * **speaking role/part** = 有對白的角色

The main semantic groups are:

- > **produce spoken language**
- > **address / converse with people**
- > **use a language**
- > **represent someone's views**
- > **figuratively communicate without literal speech**

plus a strong family of nouns and fixed expressions.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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speak — basic	用聲音說出語言內容; 說話
speak to/with someone	與某人進行口頭交流或交談
speak to an audience	以講者身份向一群聽眾正式或半正式地發言
speak in public	在一群人面前公开发言／演講
public speaking	向觀眾公開演講這項活動或能力
speak + language	能夠使用某種語言進行口頭交流
speak in + language	在某個具體場合使用指定語言口頭表達
speak about/on a topic	以口頭方式討論、講解或發表某個主題
speak at an event	在某項活動、會議或場合中以講者身份發言
speak for someone/group	代表某人／團體表達其立場、意見或決定
speak for yourself	表示某人的意見只能代表自己, 不能代表其他人
something speaks for itself	證據／結果已經非常清楚, 不需要額外解釋
speak highly/well of	以正面、讚賞的方式談論某人／某事
speak badly/poorly of	對某人／某事作負面評論
speak your mind	坦率直接地說出自己真正的想法或感受
on speaking terms	雙方關係至少維持到仍願意彼此交談
speaking voice	一個人在正常說話時所使用的聲線／聲量
spoken English/language	以口頭形式實際使用的英語／語言, 而不是書面語
spoken word	以口頭語言表達的內容; 亦可指朗誦表演形式

speaker — person	正在發言、演講或向觀眾說話的人	
speaker — device	把電子音訊轉換為可聽聲音的揚聲器／喇叭	
Speaker — institutional title	負責主持議會或正式立法會議的議長	
speaker of a language	能使用某種語言說話的人	
speech — formal talk	向觀眾正式發表的一段口頭內容／演講	
speech — ability	人類產生口語、說話和發音的能力	
speech — way of speaking	實際說話時的聲音、速度、節奏、發音等整體表現	
speech — spoken language	日常實際使用的口頭語言，而不是書面文字	
freedom of speech	公開表達思想、觀點和意見的權利；言論自由	
figure of speech	不完全按字面意思使用語言的修辭表達方式	
generally speaking	從整體／一般情況而言	
strictly speaking	按最準確、最嚴格的定義而言	
technically speaking	從專業、技術或嚴格定義的角度而言	
speaking of	因前面話題聯想到相關事情而轉入另一話題；說到……	
so to speak	表示某種說法帶比喻或近似意味；可以這樣說	
speak volumes	某種反應、行為或證據雖未直接說明，卻已傳達大量信息	
actions speak louder than words	實際行動比口頭說法更能證明態度、能力或誠意	
speaking role/part	在電影、戲劇等作品中有台詞需要說的角色	

For your original passage

> “I had never ****spoken to such a large audience in English before****.”

The exact meaning is:

****speak = 在一群聽眾面前使用口語正式表達／發言****

Therefore:

> ****speak to such a large audience****

= ****「向這麼多觀眾發言／演講」****

and:

> ****speak in English****

= ****「在這個具體場合使用英語口頭表達」****

So the full sense is:

****「用英文向一大群觀眾正式發言」****

Later:

> “While I was ****speaking****, I focused on a few friendly faces in the audience...”

Here:

****speaking = 正在台上持續向觀眾口頭表達／發言****

The most important learner contrasts are:

> ****speak to someone****

> = 跟／向某人說話

> ****speak to an audience****

> = 向觀眾發言

> ****speak English****

> = 會說英語

> ****speak in English****

> = 在某個場合用英語說話

> ****speak for the team****

> = 代表團隊發言

> ****the results speak for themselves****

> = 結果本身已說明一切

> ****speaker****

> = 講者 ****or**** 揚聲器

> ****speech****

> = 演講／說話能力／口語

So ****speak**** is much richer than simply:

> ****speak = 說話****

In your passage specifically, it combines two ideas at once:

****public-address speaking + using English as the spoken language****.